



Contemporary World History • 1st year of Bachillerato • The historian's craft • Class 1 of 6 • With Tristán

Which of the two photos is lying?



Class video: <https://youtu.be/0xWffqaQDcE>

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Before you start

1. Today a machine can make, in seconds, a photo of something that never happened. So how do we know what really happened? Answer in one sentence.
2. **At the end of the class.** Reread your answer. Would you change it? What would you add, now that you have seen how a historian works?

While you watch the video

1. What is a primary source? And a secondary one? Give an example of each.
2. **Your prediction.** Two copies of the same photo: Moscow, 5 May 1920. What has changed? Which one do you think is the original? How would you find out?

3. Why would anyone erase a man from a photo?
4. The retouched photo lies. Should we throw it in the bin? Why?
5. In the Lincoln engraving, look at the table to see what else changed. Why do you think they changed it?

The four questions

Next to each answer, mark how you know: **S** (I see it), **R** (a record or source says so), **C** (I infer it from the context) or **?** (it's not known).

Question	The retouched photo of Lenin	The Lincoln engraving
Who made it?		
When and where?		
What for?		
For whom?		
What does it tell without meaning to?		

Fact or interpretation?

Mark **F** (fact) or **I** (interpretation). If it is an interpretation, is it well supported or not? Why?

1. Trotsky is not in the retouched photo.

2. The photo was retouched so that nobody would remember Trotsky beside Lenin.

3. Trotsky was expelled from the Soviet Union in 1929.

4. Stalin gave the order to retouch this photo.

5. On the table in the Lincoln engraving you can read "Union".

6. The engraver reused Calhoun's body to save himself work.

Practice

1. Is a textbook from 1950 a primary or a secondary source? Hint: it depends on what you want to find out with it.

2. Another pair of Soviet photos (the original, from April 1937): what has changed? What would you ask it to find out why?

3. Find an old family photo at home, ask it the four questions and note down what it tells you without meaning to. You don't need to bring it: describing it is enough.

Keep thinking

Today anyone can make a photo of something that never happened. How will the historians of the future know what really happened in our time?

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